AYE
TECH HUB

• CRITICAL THINKING SERIES • NO. 04

The Socratic Method Questioning Everything

The Tool That Has Defeated Certainty for 2,400 Years.

No. 04 of 30 | Critical Thinking Series

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- Who Socrates was and why Athens sentenced him to death
- The 6 types of Socratic questions — with examples
- The elenchus: how to expose hidden contradictions in any argument
- Socratic questioning applied to AI conversations
- Using the method for self-reflection and better decisions

01 | Socrates: The Man Who Was Killed for Asking Questions

Socrates (469–399 BC) was an Athenian philosopher who never wrote a single book. Everything we know about him comes from his student Plato. Socrates walked through Athens asking people questions — politicians, craftsmen, poets, generals — exposing the gap between what they thought they knew and what they actually knew.

The city of Athens found him so dangerous that they put him on trial for "corrupting the youth" and "impiety." He was found guilty and executed by drinking hemlock in 399 BC. **His crime was asking too many questions.** His philosophy survived him by 2,400 years.

> ***"I know that I know nothing."***
>
> — Socrates (paraphrased from Plato's Apology)

02 | What Is the Socratic Method?

The Socratic Method is a form of **cooperative argumentative dialogue** that uses questions to stimulate critical thinking, expose hidden assumptions, and reveal contradictions in beliefs. It is not about winning arguments — it is about arriving at truth by systematically eliminating everything that is false.

The key insight of the Socratic Method is that **most people hold beliefs they cannot actually justify under questioning**. They have absorbed opinions from culture, media, family, or authority without ever examining them. The method makes this visible — gently but ruthlessly.

Common Belief	Socratic Question	Hidden Problem Exposed
"Hard work always leads to success."	"Can you name someone who worked extremely hard and still failed? What does that tell us about the relationship between effort and outcome?"	Survivorship bias — we only notice the successes of hard work, not the failures
"AI will take all our jobs."	"Define what you mean by 'all'. Which specific jobs? In what timeframe? Based on which evidence? What happened to jobs during previous technological revolutions?"	Vague claim — lacks definitions, evidence, and historical context
"Democracy is the best system of government."	"Best by what measure? For whom? Compared to what alternatives? Are there documented cases where democracy produced bad outcomes?"	Undefined comparison — 'best' requires a criterion and a baseline
"More education always improves society."	"What kind of education? Who defines what is good education? Are there examples of educated societies that committed atrocities?"	Assumption that education quality and availability are uniform — they are not

03 | The 6 Types of Socratic Questions

Richard Paul and Linda Elder (Foundation for Critical Thinking) organised Socratic questioning into six categories. Together they cover every dimension of an argument — its meaning, its assumptions, its evidence, its perspective, its implications, and the validity of the question itself.

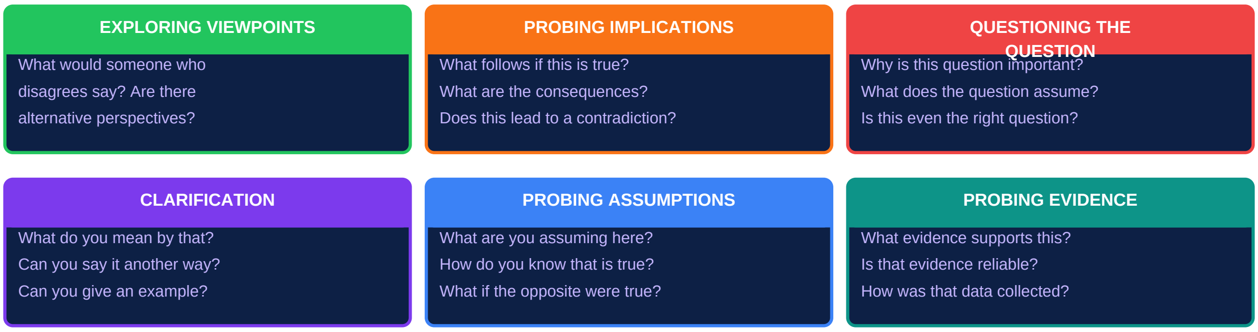

Figure 1 — The 6 Types of Socratic Questions

04 | The Elenchus — Cross-Examination in 5 Stages

The **elenchus** (Greek: examination or cross-examination) is the core procedure of the Socratic Method. It is not a confrontation — it is a structured dialogue that moves from a confident claim through questioning to a state of *aporia* (productive confusion) that opens the mind to deeper understanding.

Figure 2 — The Elenchus: Socratic Cross-Examination in 5 Stages

Stage	What Happens	Your Role
1 — Claim	The person states a belief with confidence: "Renewable energy will solve climate change."	Listen carefully. Do not challenge yet. Understand exactly what is being claimed.
2 — Question	Ask clarifying and assumption-probing questions: "What do you mean by solve? By when? What assumptions are you making about cost, grid stability, political will?"	Be genuinely curious, not hostile. Your goal is understanding, not winning.
3 — Contradiction	Through questioning, a weakness emerges: "Renewable energy alone cannot solve the baseload problem without major battery storage advances."	Point out the contradiction gently: "But earlier you said X — does that contradict what you are saying now?"
4 — Revision	The claim is refined: "Renewable energy, combined with energy storage advances and grid modernisation, can significantly reduce carbon emissions."	Accept the revision. A refined claim is progress, not defeat.

5 — Aporia	Both parties realise the topic is deeper than expected. New questions emerge. This is the productive confusion that drives genuine inquiry.	Welcome this state. Aporia means the mind is opening, not closing.

Socratic Irony

Socrates pretended not to know the answer — "Socratic irony" — to draw out the other person's thinking. This was not dishonesty; it was a technique to let the person discover contradictions in their own reasoning rather than being told they were wrong. The insight that comes from within is always more powerful than the insight imposed from outside.

05 | Question Depth — From Surface to Profound

Not all questions are equal. The pyramid below shows six levels of question depth, from simple recall at the base to evaluation at the peak. Most conversations — in classrooms, workplaces, and social media — stay at the bottom two levels. The Socratic method pushes toward the top.

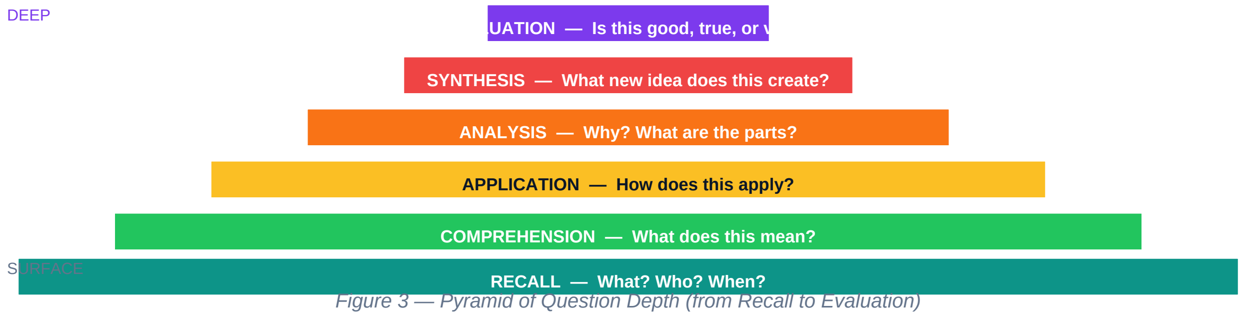

Figure 3 — Pyramid of Question Depth (from Recall to Evaluation)

06 | Applying the Socratic Method in the AI Age

The Socratic Method is the ideal antidote to AI-generated certainty. When a language model gives you a confident answer, it is not thinking — it is generating statistically plausible text. Applying Socratic questioning to AI responses is one of the most powerful critical thinking practices available today.

Context	Apply the Method Like This	What You Discover
AI gives a confident factual answer	"What is the source of this? How recent is it? Is this a consensus view or a minority opinion? What would a critic of this position say?"	AI often blends sources without attribution — confident tone masks uncertainty
AI produces a solution to your problem	"What assumptions did you make? What if those assumptions are wrong? What are the top 3 failure modes of this solution?"	Solutions often contain hidden assumptions about your specific context
AI summarises a complex debate	"Did you present both sides equally? What is the strongest argument on each side? Which side has more peer-reviewed evidence?"	AI summaries often subtly favour one side depending on training data
Someone makes a strong argument on social media	"What is the evidence for this claim? What does the opposing side say? What would I need to know to change my mind?"	Most viral arguments are emotionally compelling but logically weak
You are making a major decision	"What am I assuming? What would change if the assumption is wrong? What advice would I give a friend in this situation?"	Most bad decisions come from unexamined assumptions about the future

07 | Your Daily Socratic Practice

Practice	How to Do It	Time
Question one belief per day	Pick one thing you believe. Ask: "How do I know this? When did I adopt this view? What evidence would change my mind?"	5 min

Socratic self-interview	Before an important decision, interview yourself using all 6 question types. Write the questions and your answers.	15 min
Apply to AI outputs	Every time AI gives you a confident answer, ask at least 2 of the 6 question types before accepting the response.	2 min
Practice with a partner	Take turns: one person states a belief, the other asks Socratic questions. No debates — only questions and answers.	20 min
Read Plato's dialogues	The Apology (Socrates at trial), Meno (what is virtue?), and Euthyphro (what is piety?) are each under 30 pages and demonstrate the method live.	1-2 hrs

What comes next — CT-005

Logical Fallacies: Arguments That Sound Right But Are Wrong. Twenty of the most common logical fallacies — the errors in reasoning that win arguments but lose truth — with real examples from politics, media, workplace debates, and AI interactions.